the Swadeshi crop, ‘The managers, canvassers, shareholders or anyone of those connected with the company should refrain from taking any antagonistic stand vis-à-vis the government. We emphasize that such a stance would only bring ruin to a grand patriotic and nationalistic enterprise.’[90]

Pooncholai Muthuveera Navalar’s politely worded suggestion was articulated in particularly harsh terms by Iyotheedass Pandithar, the radical Dalit thinker. Pandithar’s loyalist position is well-known. A critic of the Indian nationalist movement, he had denounced the Swadeshi movement from its inception. Undermining the very raison d’être of SSNCo, he asked ‘Should it be called a Swadeshi shipping company?’ By making an a priori distinction between ‘our nation’ and ‘alien nation’, and painting Europeans as enemies, Pandithar said, unnecessary bad blood had been created. Only by working harmoniously would society prosper.[91] What the managers of SSNCo, fighting a battle for survival, made of such naïve advice is not known. Earlier, at the time of the Tirunelveli ‘Riots’, Pandithar had trained his guns on VOC himself. He asked if, before the current troubles, VOC had ever shown any concern for the development of Swadeshi enterprise or the common people and blamed him for unnecessarily creating enmity against the government and turning into a seditionist. If VOC had not made seditious speeches and turned the people against them, the government would never have sought to silence him.[92] Clearly, Pandithar had not kept himself informed of VOC’s tireless activities. Written at the time of VOC’s double life imprisonment, these were, to put it mildly, unfeeling words.

Appealing to the Public, Again

Amidst the flurry of responses to the company’s predicament, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar issued a series of statements addressing the public at length. Over Rs 60,000 was due from shareholders, he lamented. If only all of them subscribed fully at least the *Lawoe* would be able to sail on the coast. The company had the power to forfeit the shares which were not fully paid up but the directors hesitated to invoke an unhappy rule. However, its hands